




SC and ST women entrepreneurs, eligibility requires beneficiaries to have no outstanding/NPA loans. The programme provides loans of ₹1-3 lakh per unit, with subsidy support of up to ₹50,000, helping women start micro-enterprises without encouraging the accumulation of stressed debt.

The emphasis is therefore shifting from simply measuring credit disbursed to building enterprises that can generate income and repay sustainably.

**FROM FINANCE TO PERFORMANCE**

The impact is beginning to show across multiple livelihood sectors.

The Mahila Kisan programme benefited 29,733 women in 2025-26. Among the key livelihood initiatives, 3,038 women benefited from bamboo cultivation, 1,839 from millet-based enterprises, 1,845 from moringa, 19,079 from aqua and seaweed livelihoods, 850 from tomato and onion cultivation, 1,200 from spices, 100 from honeybee activities and 1,680 through backyard poultry.

The FPO ecosystem is another pillar of the strategy. The state reports 540 FPOs, 65,375 Farmer Producer Groups and 7.11 lakh farmers mobilised across 26 districts. FPOs are increasingly being used for procurement, food processing, storage, licensing and market access.

For 2026-27, Andhra Pradesh has set a target of 66,932 farm-sector entrepreneurs, including 29,167 Community Resource Persons as entrepreneurs, 31,703 livestock-sector entrepreneurs and 6,062 agriculture-based entrepreneurs.

**BUILDING BUSINESSES AROUND LOCAL STRENGTHS:**

The enterprise programme is deliberately diversified.

The Bamboo Mission, for instance, facilitated 1.8 lakh bamboo saplings to 3,038 women farmers across 14 mandals in six districts during 2025-26. A primary processing plant involving machinery worth □46 lakh has been established, with additional plants being considered.

The Millet Mission targets 3,875 enterprises, including 3,000 SHG women entrepreneurs and 875 millet cafés. Four hundred women have already been profiled with individual enterprise plans, with 400 units being implemented across production, processing, marketing and food services.

The Moringa Mission has identified 2,046 farmers across 432 villages and 2,384 acres in its pilot phase, while a ₹60 lakh processing plant has been purchased in Chittoor.

Such initiatives point to a larger objective: creating complete value chains rather than isolated livelihood activities.

**CONNECTING WOMEN TO MARKETS**

The next challenge after production is market access. Here too, the state is seeking partnerships.

The proposed Swayam AP brand aims to take SHG products into modern trade, e-commerce and retail markets. The initiative currently identifies 500-plus SHG women, 62 product categories and 132 SKUs across 28 districts, with an emphasis on quality, compliance, branding and traceability.

Other partnerships are creating opportunities in retail, food services, digital services and agriculture. The Ezimart initiative has 1,025 stores operational, while the Namo Drone Didi programme targets 250 women entrepreneurs in 2026-27.

Some emerging business models are already showing promising commercial potential. Six Chai Rasta outlets report a monthly turnover of ₹7.4 lakh and monthly profit of ₹3.4 lakh. Six Tripti Canteens report monthly turnover of ₹7.82 lakh and monthly profit of ₹4.3 lakh.

**THE LARGER ECONOMIC STORY**

The transformation underway in Andhra Pradesh is ultimately about changing the role of women in the local economy—from participants in livelihood programmes to owners and managers of enterprises.

The government is also planning a Mentor-Mentee programme, in convergence with MSME, aimed at covering five lakh entrepreneurs. A pool of 6,200 Community Resource Persons is being created to support women with business plans, registrations and statutory compliances, while institutions such as ISB, XLRI and IIM Visakhapatnam are part of the capacity-building ecosystem.

The approach combines scale with a growing emphasis on accountability. Credit is being linked to enterprise viability; digital systems are strengthening monitoring; NPA-free eligibility is built into select programmes; and market linkages are being pursued alongside finance.

For Andhra Pradesh, the opportunity is considerable. If these initiatives translate into viable enterprises, stronger repayment performance and sustained market demand, the state's vast SHG network could evolve into one of its most important engines of women led economic growth.

The message is increasingly clear: empowering women is no longer only about giving them access to livelihoods. It is about giving them the capital, capability, confidence and connections to build businesses of their own.